



**One for the album:** (Clockwise from left) Shafali Verma after scoring a magnificent double century. The Indian team celebrates after its win. A jubilant Sneha Rana after taking the wicket of Sinalo Jafta. PICS: B. JOTHIRAMALINGAM

not many gave the Proteas much of a chance against the Goliath that India is turning out to be in home conditions.

However, the side's batting mainstays — Wolvaardt, former captain Sune Luus, Marizanne Kapp, and the young Nadine de Klerk — led a memorable resistance to make India earn its victory, stretching them more than both England (day three) and Australia (first session of day four) had.

Luus was the chief resistor. She pulled the brakes for three and a half hours in the first innings and a bit more in the second to wear down an otherwise boisterous Indian bunch. She had help from Kapp in the first innings, but her record-breaking 190-run stand with Wolvaardt truly defined the Protean resilience that this match will be remembered for. Wolvaardt learned from her early dismissal in the first innings and dug

deep for over six and a half hours during her 314-ball 122.

Sporadic experiences of the long format condemn teams to be perennial learners. Wolvaardt had to figure out how to stay calm and power through the elements, her own doubts, and itches to score differently to drop anchor. As did the lower order, which batted for a collective 21 overs in the second innings compared to a paltry 7.5 overs in the first.

"It would be ideal to practise red-ball stuff more often, even if it's just having a few inter-squad games or camps. Maybe a full-fledged four-day league is a little bit far away, but just to practise it a bit more. Just to come into an international Test match in India with absolutely no experience in the format is tough," Wolvaardt said after the loss.

Players have always vouched for more Tests because of the

